

HIGH SCHOOL BOYS BASKETBALL 2000-01

TOP PERFORMANCES

Mike Brosovich, a 6-6 senior forward from Grand Valley, scored 31 points in a 66-51 victory over Cardinal in Chagrin Valley Conference action.

Senior Ernie Cobbin of Kent Roosevelt poured in 33 points in a 78-73 win over Kenston in Western Reserve Conference tournament action. Kenston's Matt Phillips scored 34 points in the same game.

Orange's Kendall Chones scored 33 points in a 73-66 loss to Wickliffe in the CVC's Chagrin Division. Josh Hill of North Ridgeville scored 26 points in a 61-54 loss to Brunswick.

Olmsted Falls stopped Avon Lake, 81-72, in front of a packed house to win its sixth consecutive SWC title. Bulldogs senior Mike Gansey scored 31 points.

Brush, The Plain Dealer's eighth-ranked team, took home the Western Reserve Conference championship with an 84-77 overtime victory over Barborton. The Arcs outscored the Magics, 23-16, in the extra period.

TOP GAMES

FastBREAK

Yesterday's action at a glance

By BOB FORTUNA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Birthdays are special, especially No. 18.
A person becomes eligible to vote, and there's that thing about crossing the line into adulthood.
For Eastlake North center Jim Helmink, he'll remember his 18th birthday for a couple of things.
The 6-6 senior scored a career-high 16 points and grabbed six rebounds in leading the Rangers to a come-from-behind 50-48 victory last night in a nonleague boys basketball game at Collinwood.

EASTLAKE NORTH COLLINWOOD	50 48
------------------------------	----------

"This is a nice birthday present," Helmink said. "All season long, our outside game struggled."
"Tonight we went inside and got the win."
It was also a nice present for North (7-13) for a number of reasons.
For one thing, it was a good way to close the regular season, and the victory ended a six-game losing streak.
"We needed something to give us some confidence," Helmink

said. "It's especially nice because we get our leading scorer back on Tuesday."
Nate Reed, a 6-3 senior forward, had been averaging 13.8 points and 3.9 rebounds, but missed the last three games because of a sore back.
For the Rangers, the victory was beautiful, but it had its moments of ugliness.
Like when Collinwood (10-8) outscored North, 9-4, near the end of the second quarter to take a 25-19 lead into the intermission.
Railroaders sophomore Swaney Cooper, who led all scorers with 17 points, scored four points dur-

ing the stretch, one basket coming off transition and the other on a massive dunk that rocked the partisan crowd.
Collinwood then scored six unanswered points to close the third quarter with a 40-31 lead. Four of George Blade's 14 points came during that rally, one on a reverse layup and the other on a 5-foot jumper.
But the fourth quarter was all Rangers.
They shot 77 percent (7-of-9) from the field, committed only one turnover and held a 8-5 edge in rebounds.
Mark Volpe headed North's 6-0

run at the outset of the quarter by hitting two baskets off the drive in cutting the Rangers' deficit to 40-38.
"We weren't shooting that well from the outside so we figured, let's get the ball down on the block and see what happens," Rangers coach Kirk Culler said. "But we always find a way to make things interesting."
North took its first lead with 3:28 left in the game on Keith Mayer's 10-footer. The Rangers followed by making the next four points before Collinwood retaliated to tie the game at 48-48 when Cooper's eight-foot banker hit

nothing but net with 1:12 left.
The clincher came when Sam Mainome made two foul shots to give the lead back to North at 50-48 in the final 11 seconds.
"We were 10-3 at one time this year," said Collinwood coach Ken Vana, moments after his team suffered its fourth straight defeat.
"We lost a few kids to academic eligibility a couple of weeks ago. I just don't know. Right now, we have kids just going through the motions."
"I hope we snap out of it."
E-mail: fortuna@pland.com
Phone: 216-999-4479

Rangers' Helmink celebrates 18th birthday in big way

Wickliffe cuts down nets

Devils use balanced attack to topple Lions, grab title

By MIKE PETICCA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

About 1,000 fans squeezed inside Wickliffe's tiny gymnasium last night. Others stood in a hallway, outside two open doors, hoping to catch a glimpse of a championship basketball game.
The boys from Wickliffe and Orange played with an urgency and intensity that confirmed much was at stake. And Wickliffe played a bit better, earning a 73-66 victory and the Chagrin Valley Conference Chagrin Division title.

"It was absolutely crazy," Wickliffe guard Matt Luthardt said after helping his teammates cut down the nets. "The buzz of the crowd. If you shot and the ball went through the hoop, it was a feeling you've never had before."

Luthardt, a 5-7 senior, scored 20 points. Backcourt mates Cory Rojeck and Chris Hoose scored 14 and 13 points, respectively, and 6-7 forward Dustin Kinney had 15 points and 12 rebounds.

"It's a tough league to win," said Kinney, a standout senior. "We went into the season knowing we could win it if we played hard and practiced hard. Everybody played his role."

Wickliffe, the 16th-ranked team in The Plain Dealer's Top 25, finished the regular season 17-3 overall and 9-1 in the CVC. The Blue Devils won at Orange, 71-64, earlier this season.

Orange, ranked 24th, finished 14-5, 8-2. The Lions stayed in the game until the final half-minute, thanks largely to 6-6 center-forward Kendall Chones. The left-handed junior scored 33 points and grabbed 20 rebounds.

"Kendall may be the best junior in the state," Wickliffe's first-year coach, Dave Kryz, said. "He's unstoppable when he gets the ball in the paint."

Andrew Lukich, a 6-5 forward, helped Chones with 14 points and 10 rebounds.

"It was a good fan's game," Orange coach Ron Hoyt said. "We couldn't get over the hump."

"I give a lot of credit to their guards. Rojeck, Hoose, Luthardt and a couple others — they have

#18 WICKLIFFE	73
#24 ORANGE	66

"It was absolutely crazy. The buzz of the crowd. If you shot and the ball went through the hoop, it was a feeling you've never had before."

MATT LUTHARDT,
Wickliffe guard

very good perimeter players. They play quick. Our third guy always has to cover one of their guards."

Orange's last lead was at 21-20 early in the second quarter. The last tie, 46-46, came midway through the third quarter.

Wickliffe then went on a 14-7 run to lead, 60-53, with six minutes left in the game. Kinney sparked the rally with a 3-point shot and a short baseline jumper. Luthardt made three free throws and a jump shot, and Rojeck and Hoose each converted layups.

"We had good ball reversal," Kinney said of the Blue Devils' balanced offense. "We made them work on defense. That tires out a defense."

Chones, who had six fourth-quarter baskets, kept the Lions close, and they cut the Wickliffe lead to 70-66 on a 3-point shot by Craig Fuller with 30 seconds to go. Seven seconds later, Luthardt made two free throws to give the Blue Devils a six-point lead.

Wickliffe's Mike Frantz contributed eight points and five rebounds.

"We've got two or three scorers," Kryz said, "and guys like Brandon Dorsey who go out and play defense and guys like Mike Frantz, who go out and get a few points and rebounds. We've done it all year."

E-mail: mpeticca@pland.com
Phone: 440-602-4785



CHL. PETE COPELAND / THE PLAIN DEALER

Chris Hoose moves past Orange's Craig Fuller during the third quarter of Wickliffe's 73-66 victory.

Arcs overcome Magics' rally to win WRC title

By E.L. ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

It was one of those in-your-face moments.

Poster time.
Early in last night's game, Brush basketball player Roy Hall Jr. got busy. He glided to the rim and threw it home. A nasty facial sent down Barborton's throat. And that's the way things went in the early moments of this Western Reserve Conference championship game. Brush could do nothing wrong, and Barborton could do nothing right.

It seemed like the visiting Magics didn't have a prayer by the end of the third quarter.

So how did this game all of a sudden become a thriller? How did the Magics rally and send this game into overtime before finally

#8 BRUSH	84
#21 BARBORTON	77

falling, 84-77?

"In the first half, we just couldn't get anything done," said Barborton coach Ken Rector. "At halftime, I talked to my kids about having some guts. We played a completely gutless first half, just gutless. We looked like we had never played the game before."

There was a reason Barborton (15-5 overall) played like the Little Rascals in the first half: Brush's defense. It was downright swarming, and it led to some easy transition baskets for the Arcs. By the end of the first quarter, Brush (17-3) had a 21-10 lead.

When that cushion grew to 20 points midway through the sec-

ond period, some of the folks in the crowd thought about leaving.

But not so fast.
"We didn't keep our composure when we were up," Hall said. "Barborton is a good team, and good teams find a way to come back. But even when they started coming back, I still thought by the end of the game we'd have a W."

Just barely.
Brush coach Jed Dunn said he could see it coming.

"I didn't want to say anything to my kids, but I figured this was going to be a close game," Dunn said. "I grew up playing against Barborton, and I can remember they always found ways to make a comeback if they were down."

That would explain why Brush's 46-30 lead after three quarters bottomed out. The Mag-

"We played a completely gutless first half, just gutless. We looked like we had never played the game before."

KEN RECTOR, Barborton coach

ics, sparked by four 3-pointers during that stretch from Bryan Janiga, took a 55-53 lead with four minutes left in the game on a 3-pointer from the left wing by Janiga. He finished the night with five 3-pointers.

"His 3-pointers definitely hurt us," Dunn said.

At the end of regulation, the teams were knotted at 61. Brush opened the overtime with a 3-pointer from left wing by Dejuan Walker. Barborton never re-

gained the lead. Brush stretched the score to 80-72 with 24 seconds left on a couple of free throws by Ryan Haber.

"Yeah, they came back on us, but when you get a big lead like we did tonight, sometimes you might get down a little and the other team comes back," Walker said. "We just showed we wanted it in the end more than they did."

E-mail: erogers@pland.com
Phone: 216-999-4267



After the whistle

Check out Cleveland Live for your most complete coverage of high school sports this winter season at: www.cleveland.com/highsports

Get Plain Dealer stories and previews, chat LIVE with other fans and get the inside scoop on your team.

THE PLAIN DEALER
HIGH SCHOOL
SPORTS INSIDER

Tomorrow, 10 a.m., FOX-8

Players of the Week: Time is running out

The winter season is winding down, and that means time is running out for coaches to nominate Players of the Week. Because of some winter sports reaching the district level, nominations will be taken tomorrow only for gymnastics and boys and girls basketball.
The Plain Dealer will accept nominations tomorrow from 10 a.m. to 2 p.m. There is one number to call for the seven-county coverage area: 800-388-4370. If you want to pay for the call, dial 216-999-4370.